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Lifelong Learning: My Guide to a Sustainable and Rewarding Study Habit

by Miles Raymer

This is a kind of meta-post about my study habits, and was written in response to a request from one of my readers. “How have you managed to stay so disciplined in this endeavor?” he asked. He was particularly curious to hear about the “tactics and vital choreographies” that “make your extensive reading and writing possible,” as he put it.

My study habits are not something I’ve written much about, either publicly or privately. I’ve avoided it mainly because I don’t think what I’ll have to say on this topic is very different from numerous other resources one could already find on the web. But since there appears to be at least one person who wants to hear what I have to say on this topic, I’m happy to oblige. Below is a list of a dozen items that I believe make up the core of how I’ve been able to study consistently for nearly a decade with little incentive beyond my own intrinsic motivation. But before we begin, there are a few contextual points I want to make.

First, in my individual case, the term “study” refers primarily to reading and writing in the service of self-expression and self-improvement. So when I say “study time,” what I mean specifically is time spent either reading books or writing book reviews, essays, journals, or the occasional poem. More generally, this can broaden into “consumption” of whatever you like to study (books, articles, visual media, films, music, etc.) and “production” of whatever you make in order to synthesize and solidify the information you take in. Successful implementation of a “study habit” simply means that you develop and maintain a system of routines that ensures repeated execution of high-quality learning for your own purposes, whatever they may be.

Second, I want to acknowledge that one must have *time* and *energy* to create and sustain a strong study habit. In my view, the primary reason that I’ve been able to study so much and so consistently has almost nothing to do with me. It stems from the hard work and generosity of my wife and mother, who have supported me financially to the point where I’ve never had to work so much that I became too busy or too exhausted to keep studying. I should add that never once has either of them pushed me to try to monetize my writing, nor have they ever questioned the value of me spending countless hours reading and writing with no particular goal beyond my own intellectual exploration. This is a gift of immeasurable value, one I

am grateful for every day. There are, of course, many adults who manage to study despite working full-time, having kids, and staying on top of numerous other responsibilities, but I want to make it very clear that *I am not one of these people*.

Third, if you're trying to monetize your study habit as a full-time vocation or part-time side hustle, that's totally cool, but you've come to the wrong place. I've never tried this and almost certainly would fail if I did. None of my advice is intended to help your study habit become a source of income, and I think some of my recommendations would actually make it *more difficult* to achieve that goal.

Okay, here's the list! The items that come earliest are the ones I consider most essential.

1. Make studying a core component of your identity

I really think this one recommendation is the most important, and if you can manage it then the rest will sort itself out in time. You don't want to be someone who has studied, or who studies when necessary, or who can study. You want to be a scholar, a researcher, a lifelong learner. You're not a person who reads, *you're a reader*. You're not a person who writes, *you're a writer*. Using this language as a framing mechanism—both in your own head and in your discussions with others—will help to integrate your study habit into the core of your personal identity. Once that's done, it actually becomes harder to *not* study than to study.

2. Study (almost) every day

Okay, but how do you practically get to the point where you can call yourself a reader, a writer, a scholar, or whatever, with a straight face? You get there by putting in the work, which means studying almost every day of your life. The only exceptions should be holidays, vacations, or emergencies. Seriously.

In order to study regularly, figure out your chronotype, identify your sweet spot in the day, and try to carve out at least 1.5 hours of uninterrupted study time (less is okay, and anything is better than nothing!). If you don't have a strong instinct as to what time of day is best, experiment until you find a window that works for you. Then lock it in, and get stubborn. Guard this time like a prized possession—don't give it up except in extreme situations. Also, try to study every day, but *don't* study *all* day. I've found that 2-4 hours per day is ideal, after which time it's best to leave off until tomorrow and go do other things. Mental downtime, sleep, exercise, nutrition, and social connection are absolutely critical for your learning and creative process, and if you shortchange these aspects of your life your studying will suffer.

3. Eliminate distractions

This is especially important if you study during normal business hours or when you have a reasonable expectation that people will be trying to contact you. Personally, I have found it's best to study early in the

morning when most people are still sleeping or just waking up. Make it clear to your family, colleagues, and/or roommates that you are not to be bothered during this time and that you will not be taking calls or responding to texts/emails. Digital notifications and other interruptions will break your flow, slowing you down and diluting your learning process. Silence or turn off your phone at a minimum, and consider removing it entirely from the room where you are studying. If you study using a computer, turn off notifications during your study time. I believe there are plenty of apps to help with this if you need support.

4. Take notes

Your notes can be digital or handwritten, but having notes of some kind is much better than not having them. There are lots of apps and systems available, but I think the process of creating your own note-taking style is hugely beneficial and applicable to virtually any type of serious and meaningful work. Notes are also a great resource whenever you pivot from consumption of other people's work to producing your own work. I started using [Roam Research](#) in 2020 and absolutely love it.

5. Prioritize process over product

Studying is the never-finished process of attempting to make yourself a more informed, effectual, compassionate, and ethical person. Keeping this process alive and vital, regardless of how it manifests during any given period of your life, is far more important than anything you "produce" as a result of your study habit. Another way to frame it is that the primary product of your study habit is *you*; everything else is secondary.

6. Prioritize quality over quantity

This is true both for how prolific you are and also for measurement tools such as clicks, likes, shares, subscribers, etc. Unless you're trying to make it as a professional writer, giving a shit about quantified metrics or obsessing about if you're "producing enough" will most likely just distract you and degrade the quality of your work. If you think something's good, that's enough. Don't rely on external validation to keep you going. I personally have almost no idea how many people read my writing, except for being able to see likes on [my Goodreads profile](#) and the number of subscribers to [my newsletter](#). My policy is that if anything I write improves the life of another person, even just once, then it was worth it. And even if not, it's still worth it if the only life it improves is mine.

7. Follow your natural curiosity

This isn't always possible in a world where educational or professional assignments sometimes dominate our study time, but in periods where those demands are low, follow your curiosity wherever it leads. Don't study something just because you feel obligated or because it's popular. If you're into stuff that's

particularly unusual, all the better. Studying is the ultimate arena in which you should seek to cultivate your particular weirdness and let your freak flag fly!

8. Allow yourself to waste time

The Israeli historian Yuval Noah Harari said this best:

If you want to go deeply into any subject, you need a lot of time, and in particular you need the privilege of wasting time. You need to experiment with unproductive paths, explore dead ends, make space for doubts and boredom, and allow little seeds of insight to slowly grow and blossom. If you cannot afford to waste time, you will never find the truth. (*21 Lessons for the 21st Century*, 225)

9. Treat studying as a mode of social connection

Although you should generally follow your personal instincts wherever they lead, I recommend cultivating a study habit that is socially-sensitive. This means studying things that people you love care about, especially if you share a strong intellectual connection with them. Reaching out to others for advice can be an especially good dynamic to tap into if you feel unsure about what to study next. It's amazing how positively people respond when you take the time to fully engage with their recommendations. Some of my best experiences over the years have been reading books as a means of connecting with loved ones, or producing pieces of writing that were intended to strengthen and deepen relationships with family and friends.

10. Create study projects and deadlines

When you come up with a good idea for a study project (e.g. an essay you want to write), create arbitrary deadlines to keep yourself on track. Then, try to beat those deadlines. This may seem silly, but in my experience it works and is super satisfying. Another good strategy is to commit to recurring study projects (e.g. my annual Bookish Wisdom essays). In many cases, you'll want to trick yourself into thinking you've "got no choice" but to get the thing done on time. Also, while repetition and routine are generally your friends here, be open to change when you get stuck in a rut. I've recently done this by producing more poetry and switching up my book review format, which has taken my writing in some really fun and enriching directions.

11. Be fine with finishing

When it comes to anything you produce, go ahead and be a perfectionist for a while, but figure out when to cut yourself off from the revision process. Nothing you make is ever going to be perfect, so develop a sense

of what “good enough” means to you and then call it good. Getting something imperfect but worthwhile out into the world is much better than getting nothing out there. Don’t let the perfect be the enemy of the good, as they say, and learn to let your work go and take on a life of its own.

12. Get nerdy about language

If you don’t already, teach yourself to care a lot about the precise meanings of words, especially the subtle differences between words that are often (mis)used interchangeably. Whatever you study, it’s important to comprehend and utilize the nomenclature of any field, and doing so will help you develop a unique voice that’s a hybrid of standardized usage and your own creative twist on things. As a counterbalance, avoid becoming pedantic. Always keep in mind that words are tools for conveying meaning and building connections and consensus between minds, not weapons for gaining power or demonstrating superiority over others.